hostage to Buddhist-nationalist discourses. Neither incumbents nor the opposition could afford to publicly display any empathy towards Muslim minority causes during the campaign, or risk losing votes.

Deadlock in Rakhine State

Internationally, anti-Muslim sentiment, inter-communal violence, and Muslim disenfranchisement in Myanmar are mostly associated with Rakhine State and the disputed legal status of its Muslim population. These developments are part of the national discourse on Islam, and are sometimes directly influenced by extremist Buddhist leaders. The dire humanitarian situation of most Muslims in northern Rakhine State led INGOs and NGOs to provide support, although this was at times hindered by the military government. The aid was mainly directed towards returning refugees, but was perceived to leave out the majority of the Rakhine population, which in Myanmar is also marginalized and poor. This situation hardened the Rakhines' deep dislike of their Muslim neighbours.

The 1982 Citizenship Law (which establishes complex rules governing citizenship by descent), its 1983 Procedures, and a citizenship inspection process in 1989 worsened the already difficult conditions for Muslim people in Rakhine State to acquire or maintain citizenship status — and, in fact, made many who had citizenship stateless. While this has been the case for nearly two decades, the politics of identity and identity labels increased over recent years and notably worsened in the 2015 pre-election context. Prior to 2012, Muslims lived as integrated minorities in Sittwe and across many townships of northern/central Rakhine State — although settlements were often separated in rural areas where the impoverished Muslim population is cut off from the outside world.

Following the rape of a Rakhine Buddhist woman by Muslim men and retaliation for this act with a revenge killing of Muslim travellers in May/June 2012, violence erupted in and around the state capital of Sittwe and subsequently led to the displacement of 145,000 people (ICG 2014). The great majority of the displaced live in Sittwe and neighbouring townships. While many are stateless Muslims, Rakhine and Kaman — who are officially Myanmar ethnic nationals — are also included. For most of these people, return to their place of origin is not expected anytime soon.[17] As a result of the 2012 violence and displacement, the March/April 2014 census exercise